INDIA@PARIS 2024

ANTIM PANGHAL, 19

***Wrestling** 53kg*

All of 11, Antim had just begun going to the *akhada* when her mother showed her "Sakshi Di" [Sakshi Malik] receiving a bronze medal at the Rio Olympics on TV. Eight years later, the two-time under-20 world champion, winner of the Rising Star of the Year by United World Wrestling in 2023, is a favourite to emulate Malik. "It feels great that people expect me to win a medal," she says. At the SAI centre in Hisar, she's working to achieve the goal. "Everyone trains, but one who does it properly stands out. You have to respect everyone and conduct yourself well," she says, sounding wise beyond her years. Seeded fourth in the 53 kg category, Antim appeared thrilled with her draw, one that ensures she avoids a duel with the favoured Japanese wrestler Akari Fujinami, 20, until the finals. Much like her name, Antim intends to be the last woman standing. ■



UNITED WORLD WRESTLING



GETTY IMAGES

VINESH PHOGAT, 29

***Wrestling** 50kg*

Phogat has been through hell and back in the past year and a half. As one of the faces of the wrestlers' protest against politician and erstwhile Wrestling Federation of India president Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, she lost valuable time on the mat due to her fight for justice. She then had a knee injury which led to missing the 2023 Asian Games, and on her return was compelled to change her weight category from the preferred 53kg to 50kg to make the cut to Paris. That she is still in contention—Sakshi Malik is retired and Tokyo bronze medallist Bajrang Punia failed to qualify—shows her immense resilience as a grappler who has won every honour in wrestling, barring the coveted Olympic medal. In Rio, her Olympic dream was cut short in heartbreaking fashion, after she sustained a knee injury in a bout, and in Tokyo she was the reigning world No. 1 and top seed in her weight class, only to lose in the quarters. In Paris, Phogat intends to write the final chapter of a decorated career. ■

